

What about the emotional intelligence of board members?

Quite often in the life of a Board of Directors or Supervisory Board, when considering ways to improve its composition, the profile of a current member or of a candidate for a director position is assessed.

The recommended approach is to start from the company's pre-defined strategy and from the board's current/anticipated composition to deduce the right profiles. Typically, objective characteristics are noted (age, gender, place of residence, availability, knowledge of the company's sector and countries, etc.), followed by a broad assessment of rational/cognitive intelligence (education, professional experience, etc.).

But what about emotional intelligence?

Anyone who has served on a board knows how much each person's emotion-driven behavior affects others and strongly influences the board's effectiveness. Common patterns include: the "authoritarian" chair who doesn't pick up on others' expectations; the frustrated director who feels unheard and stops contributing; the talkative member focused on self-promotion, oblivious to growing irritation; the female director stung by a gender-related remark; those unable to perceive and interpret others' unconscious body language; and, conversely, members whose empathy and contagious enthusiasm lift the group.

To analyze emotional intelligence, Wikipedia presents Goleman's model:

- **Self-awareness:** the ability to understand one's emotions, recognize their influence, and use them to guide decisions.
- **Self-regulation:** managing one's emotions and impulses and adapting to changing circumstances.
- **Social awareness:** detecting and understanding others' emotions and responding appropriately.
- **Relationship management:** the ability to inspire and influence others while supporting their development and managing conflicts.

Moreover, everyone's emotional intelligence can be improved.

Without claiming to determine an "emotional coefficient" for each person, highlighting the most salient traits of this intelligence supports the design of board compositions. Women's natural "emotional coefficient" is commonly recognized as, on average, higher than men's. Appointing more women to boards therefore has, a priori, a beneficial effect.

Gouvernance & Structures can very quickly respond to a chair's specific requests: diagnosing existing profiles on the board, increasing female representation, and supporting the case for shortlisted female candidates.

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